

Ancient Egyptian painting

As ancient Egyptian art was predominantly created to help the dead reach the afterlife, artists had to show the gods how the deceased had lived. Artists therefore did not try to replicate the real world, and no attempt was made to represent depth or texture. Like Egyptian sculpture, paintings had to be unambiguous, displaying the most representative aspects of everything. For instance, faces and limbs were shown in profile, eyes and shoulders from the front. Objects such as trees, boats and houses were depicted sideways on, rivers and fish from above. Differences in scale conveyed hierarchy; men were larger and darker-skinned than women.

Working methods were disciplined. Everything was planned on grids, colours were flat and bright. Pigments (mostly mineral) were chosen to withstand strong sunlight without fading. Paintings were created on tomb walls and papyrus. After c.1550 BCE, the *Book of the Dead*, an illustrated papyrus scroll buried with the dead, played a key role in transition to the afterlife.



Hunting scene of Pharaoh Nebamun, c.1350 BCE